

[markets] build loyalty and—more important—make people want to extend themselves to the degree that corporations need today: to be flexible, concerned, and willing to pitch in. That’s what a social relationship delivers.” (page 90)

Hence, in the less-predictable world of *Homo sapiens*, businesses must decide the extent to which they participate with their employees and customers in monetary and/or social markets.

As a follow-on to Heyman and Ariely’s (2004) experiments exploring the payment-effort trade-off, Vohs et al. (2006) sought to understand the behavioral psychology underscoring the trade-off. In its most general terms, the authors’ hypothesis is that money makes *Homo sapiens* feel self-sufficient and behave accordingly. When reminded of money, people desire to be free from dependency upon others and prefer that others not depend upon them. Vohs et al. designed several experiments to test this hypothesis from a variety of angles.

In one experiment, the authors found that participants (a sample of University of Minnesota students) who were reminded about money—both Monopoly money and real money—in the context of a series of word descrambling tasks worked longer at the tasks than participants in a non-money-primed control group before requesting help from the experimenter.²⁵ In subsequent experiments with different groups of students, Vohs et al. found that (1) participants in a high-money treatment worked significantly longer than participants in a low-money treatment before asking for help from another available participant, (2) participants in a money-primed treatment volunteered to help code fewer data sheets than did participants in the non-money-primed control condition, (3) participants in a high-money treatment volunteered to gather fewer pencils that had spilled onto the floor than did participants in a low-money treatment, and (4) participants in a money-primed treatment donated significantly less money to a university student fund than participants in the non-money primed control. Three final experiments tested the effects of money on social intimacy, desire to engage in leisure activities alone, and preference to work alone. As expected, participants who were primed with money ahead of time were subsequently less socially intimate and exhibited a stronger preference for engaging in leisure activities and working alone.

So yes, Vohs et al.’s experiments suggest that money makes *Homo sapiens* feel self-sufficient and behave accordingly.

PRICE AND THE PLACEBO EFFECT

Is it possible that the magnitudes of placebo effects experienced by *Homo sapiens* (e.g., through medical therapies or medications) are somehow influenced by the prices we pay for them? To investigate this possibility, Waber et al. (2008) studied the effect of price on a group of *Homo sapiens*’ analgesic responses to placebo pills. Over 80 healthy volunteers in Boston, MA were recruited via an online advertisement to participate in a field experiment where each participant was informed by a brochure about a purported new opioid analgesic recently approved by the Food and Drug Administration. The opioid was described as similar to codeine but with a faster onset time. In reality, and not disclosed to the participants, the pill was a placebo. After randomization, half of the participants were informed that the drug had a regular price of \$2.50 per pill (“regular price”), and half of the participants that

25. The descrambling task consisted of 30 sets of five jumbled words. Participants created sensible phrases using four of the five words. In the control and play-money treatment, the phrases primed neutral concepts (e.g., “cold it desk outside is” became “it is cold outside”). In the real-money treatment, 15 of the phrases primed the concept of money (e.g., “high a salary desk paying” became “a high-paying salary”), whereas the remaining 15 were neutral phrases. Participants in the play-money treatment were primed with money by a stack of Monopoly money in their visual periphery while completing the neutral descrambling task.